Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 5.3 Guided Notes: Explaining and Classifying Psychological Disorders

Unit 5: Mental and Physical Health | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic5.3

Word Bank

Eclectic Approach	*Ageism*	*Deviation from Social Norms*
Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM)	*Racism*	*Distress*
Sexism	*International Classification of Mental Disorders (ICD)*	*Discrimination*
Social Norms	*Dysfunction*	*Stigma*

1. Identifying Psychological Disorders

What exactly transforms a quirky behavior or an emotional struggle into a diagnosable psychological disorder? Mental health professionals rely on a combination of highly specific criteria and foundational perspectives to figure out where a normal behavior ends and a psychological disorder begins. In the real world, most psychologists employ an _____, using more than one psychological perspective when diagnosing and treating their clients, recognizing that the human mind is complex and multifaceted.

Diagnosing a disorder is not about simply identifying a strange behavior. Professionals evaluate specific factors to determine if an individual's behaviors and mental processes cross the line into a disorder. These primarily include:

- _____: This refers to thoughts, emotions, or behaviors that actively interfere with a person's ability to function effectively in their daily life. (e.g., Having a phobia of germs that is so intense you cannot leave the house to go to work.)
- _____: This is a state of significant emotional discomfort or suffering. A true disorder usually causes severe inner turmoil for the individual experiencing it.
- _____: This occurs when an individual's thoughts, emotions, or behaviors significantly differ from culturally accepted expectations or rules of behavior within a group. It is important to note that _____ differ drastically across different cultures, so what is considered unusual in one society might be perfectly normal in another.

The 3 D's: Psychologists use these three criteria to identify and evaluate disorders.

Apply It: Which Identifying Idea?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A man's constant, overwhelming worry makes him so unable to concentrate that he has lost his job and can no longer manage his bills.	
2	A teen describes constant, intense dread and inner suffering that he hides from everyone while he still goes to work each day.	
3	A man in a small town loudly announces to strangers each morning that he receives daily messages from the moon, a behavior that sharply departs from what his community considers acceptable.	
4	A traveler learns that a gesture considered rude at home is perfectly polite in the country she is visiting, because accepted rules of behavior differ across cultures.	
5	Rather than committing to a single theory, a school psychologist draws on ideas from several perspectives to understand a student's difficulties.	

2. The Diagnostic Tools and Their Consequences

Diagnosing psychological disorders requires specialized training and the strict use of evidence-based tools. The two primary manuals used worldwide are updated regularly to be responsive to new research and practice advances:

- _____: Developed by the American Psychiatric Association, this is the primary manual used in the United States to classify and diagnose mental disorders based on standardized criteria.
- _____: Developed by the World Health Organization, this system classifies diseases and health conditions, including mental and behavioral disorders, globally.

While assigning a clinical label to a patient can be incredibly helpful for creating a treatment plan, diagnosing or classifying psychological disorders has both positive and negative consequences. A formal diagnosis can unfortunately lead to _____ (a negative label attached to individuals with disorders). This negative labeling is often compounded by cultural/societal norms and can intersect with systemic issues like _____ (prejudice based on race), _____ (prejudice based on sex or gender), _____ (prejudice based on age), and broad _____ (unfair treatment of a group), causing unfair prejudice toward the individual being diagnosed.

Apply It: Which Tool or Consequence?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A U.S. psychiatrist matches a patient's symptoms to standardized criteria in the American Psychiatric Association's manual.	
2	A public-health worker in another country uses the World Health Organization's classification system to record mental and behavioral conditions.	

#	Scenario	Concept
3	After a coworker's diagnosis becomes known, others whisper about her and avoid her, branding her as “crazy.”	
4	A clinician is quicker to assume that patients of one racial group are dangerous or uncooperative, no matter what their symptoms are.	
5	A doctor dismisses a woman's symptoms as “just hormones” and doesn't investigate further.	
6	A doctor dismisses an elderly patient's depression as “just part of getting old.”	

Word Bank

Cognitive Perspective	*Biological Perspective*	*Humanistic Perspective*
Biopsychosocial Model	*Evolutionary Perspective*	*Psychodynamic Perspective*
Diathesis-Stress Model	*Behavioral Perspective*	*Sociocultural Perspective*

3. How Different Perspectives Explain Disorders

Psychologists use different theoretical lenses to understand the root causes of psychological disorders. While modern psychology heavily favors an integrated approach (see Section 4), it is crucial to understand how each individual perspective explains psychopathology. Here is a breakdown of the major psychological perspectives and how they might analyze specific conditions:

- The _____ (The Medical Model): This approach views psychological disorders as medical diseases with distinct physical, physiological, or biochemical causes. It looks for explanations in genetics, neurotransmitter imbalances, brain structure abnormalities, and evolutionary predispositions. (e.g., Schizophrenia is heavily analyzed through the biological lens. It is often explained by the Dopamine Hypothesis, an overactivity of dopamine receptors in the brain, and genetic predispositions passed down through families.)
- The _____: Rooted in the work of Sigmund Freud, this approach argues that psychological disorders stem from unresolved, unconscious conflicts, often originating from childhood trauma. Symptoms are viewed as outward manifestations of the battle between the id, ego, and superego, or as extreme defense mechanisms failing to keep painful memories repressed. (e.g., Dissociative Identity Disorder (DID) can be explained as a massive, extreme defense mechanism. To protect the conscious mind from severe, unbearable childhood trauma, the ego fragments the personality into distinct identities to hold and isolate the traumatic memories.)
- The _____: This perspective completely ignores the unconscious mind, arguing that all abnormal behavior is simply learned through the environment. Disorders are developed and maintained through classical conditioning (pairing associations), operant conditioning (reinforcement and punishment), or observational learning. (e.g., Specific Phobias are easily explained by classical conditioning. If a child is bitten by a dog, they pair the neutral stimulus (dog) with the unconditioned stimulus (pain), leading to a conditioned fear response. The fear is then maintained through operant conditioning: avoiding the dog brings relief, which negatively reinforces the avoidance.)
- The _____: This approach focuses heavily on how we process information. It suggests that psychological distress is not caused directly by events, but rather by our irrational, maladaptive interpretations of those events. Faulty thinking patterns, negative schemas, and distorted thoughts fuel emotional

disorders. (e.g., Major Depressive Disorder is often explained by the Cognitive Triad, a pattern of negative thoughts about oneself, the world, and the future, or through "learned helplessness," where an individual interprets setbacks as internal, stable, and completely unchangeable.)

- The _____: Believing that humans are inherently good and driven toward self-actualization, this perspective explains disorders as the result of a blocked path to personal growth. If a person experiences a lack of unconditional positive regard, or if there is a massive gap between their "real self" and their "ideal self," they will experience psychological distress. (e.g., Generalized Anxiety Disorder (GAD) might be explained as a result of a person growing up with strict "conditions of worth." If they only received love when they met impossible standards, they may develop a chronic, underlying anxiety that they are never good enough and are always on the verge of losing approval.)
- The _____: This lens pulls back to look at the broader environment, emphasizing how systemic factors, cultural norms, socioeconomic status, prejudice, and societal expectations shape mental health. It argues that what is considered "abnormal" is highly dependent on the cultural context in which the person lives. (e.g., Eating Disorders (like Anorexia Nervosa) are highly correlated with cultural and social factors. They are significantly more prevalent in Western cultures that heavily promote and idealize extreme thinness in media, tying a person's social value and self-worth to an unrealistic body image.)
- The _____: This approach looks at psychological disorders through the lens of natural selection, proposing that many behaviors and mental processes we now consider "disordered" once served an adaptive purpose for our ancestors, or that they reduce the likelihood of survival when a normally protective system misfires in a modern environment. (e.g., Anxiety Disorders are sometimes explained through the "smoke detector principle": it was evolutionarily safer for our ancestors to have an oversensitive alarm system that triggered fear in response to ambiguous threats, even though that same system now produces chronic, disproportionate anxiety in a much safer modern world.)

Apply It: Which Perspective Explains It?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A psychiatrist attributes a man's disorder to an imbalance in his brain chemistry and a strong genetic history in his family.	
2	A therapist believes a woman's panic attacks come from unresolved, unconscious conflicts from childhood and from defense mechanisms that are failing to keep painful memories buried.	
3	After being stuck in a stalled elevator, a boy now feels terror in every elevator and avoids them, which brings him relief each time. His therapist explains the fear as learned through association and reinforced by avoidance.	
4	A clinician explains that a client's anxiety arises not from the events themselves but from his habit of interpreting every small mistake as proof that he is a total failure.	
5	A counselor explains that a young man's distress comes from a huge gap between who he is and who he feels he should be, along with a lack of total acceptance from the people around him.	

#	Scenario	Concept
6	A researcher argues that rates of a mental health condition are higher in one community because of poverty, discrimination, and cultural expectations about how people should behave.	
7	A psychologist proposes that a person's intense fear of snakes is a leftover of a protective system that kept our ancestors alive but now misfires.	

4. The Interaction Models

Because humans are complex, modern psychology often relies on comprehensive models that combine multiple elements rather than looking through just one lens:

- _____: An approach that assumes any psychological problem potentially involves a combination of biological (genetics), psychological (thoughts/emotions), and sociocultural (environment/culture) factors.
- _____: This specific model assumes that mental disorders develop due to a combination of a genetic vulnerability and stressful life experiences. Even if you have the genetic code for a disorder, it might never appear unless triggered by a traumatic or stressful event.

Apply It: Which Interaction Model?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A clinician assessing a teen considers his family history of depression, his negative thoughts, and the stress of living in an unsafe neighborhood, all together.	
2	Twins share a genetic vulnerability to panic disorder, but only the twin who survived a serious accident develops the disorder.	

📺 *Video Notes: "Psychological Disorders" (Crash Course Psychology #28)*

This video covers the history of how disorders have been understood and diagnosed, so some of it goes beyond what's on the page (such as asylums and Rosenhan's experiments), and the page covers ideas the video doesn't (such as the individual perspectives, the ICD, and the diathesis-stress model). Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. What did Nellie Bly and David Rosenhan's first experiment reveal about psychiatric hospitals?

2. What happened in the second part of Rosenhan's experiment, and what questions did his work raise?

3. How does the video say mental health clinicians define a psychological disorder?

4. What is the medical model of psychological disorder, and how did it develop?

5. What is the biopsychological approach, according to the video, and why do most contemporary psychologists prefer it?

6. What is the DSM-5, who uses it, how does it change over time, and what criticisms does the video mention?

5. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Biopsychosocial vs. Diathesis-Stress: These two sound incredibly similar, but there is a key distinction to watch out for. The _____ is a broad umbrella looking at the intersection of body, mind, and environment. The _____ specifically deals with a dormant genetic vulnerability (diathesis) that must be "turned on" or triggered by a specific environmental stressor.

6. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. A man's intense fear of germs has become so severe and overwhelming that he is completely unable to leave his house to go to work, effectively preventing him from carrying out basic daily responsibilities. This criterion, used to identify a psychological disorder, is called:

- **A.** Stigma
- **B.** Distress
- **C.** Deviation from Social Norms
- **D.** Dysfunction

2. A woman experiences profound, severe inner turmoil and significant emotional suffering because of her persistent, intrusive negative thoughts, even though she is still managing to attend work and complete her daily tasks. This criterion, used to identify a psychological disorder, is called:

- **A.** Distress
- **B.** The Diathesis-Stress Model
- **C.** Dysfunction
- **D.** Deviation from Social Norms

3. A therapist treating a client with anxiety does not rely on just one single theory, but instead incorporates elements of cognitive therapy, medication management, and behavioral techniques all together into one single, well-rounded treatment plan. This practice, common among most real-world psychologists, is called the:

- **A.** Biopsychosocial Model Exclusively
- **B.** Diathesis-Stress Model
- **C.** Medical Model
- **D.** Eclectic Approach

4. A therapist explains that a client's severe depression stems from her persistent negative thought patterns about herself, the world, and her future, a pattern known as the Cognitive Triad, rather than from the actual events in her life themselves. This explanation, focusing on irrational interpretations of events, reflects the:

- **A.** Evolutionary Perspective
- **B.** Sociocultural Perspective
- **C.** Cognitive Perspective
- **D.** Behavioral Perspective

5. A counselor explains that a client's Generalized Anxiety Disorder developed because he grew up in a household with strict "conditions of worth," only receiving love and approval when he met his parents' impossible standards, leaving him chronically anxious that he is never good enough. This explanation, focused on a blocked path to personal growth, reflects the:

- **A.** Psychodynamic Perspective
- **B.** Biological Perspective
- **C.** Humanistic Perspective
- **D.** Behavioral Perspective

6. A researcher notes that eating disorders like Anorexia Nervosa are significantly more prevalent in Western cultures that heavily promote and idealize extreme thinness in media, tying a person's social value and self-worth to an unrealistic body image. This explanation, emphasizing systemic and cultural factors, reflects the:

- **A.** Cognitive Perspective
- **B.** Sociocultural Perspective
- **C.** Psychodynamic Perspective
- **D.** Biological Perspective

7. A woman carries a genetic predisposition for developing severe depression that runs in her family, but she never actually develops any symptoms of the disorder until she experiences the sudden, traumatic loss of her job and her spouse within the same year. This model, which assumes a genetic vulnerability must be triggered by a stressful life event, is called the:

- **A.** Diathesis-Stress Model
- **B.** Medical Model
- **C.** Biopsychosocial Model
- **D.** Sociocultural Perspective

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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